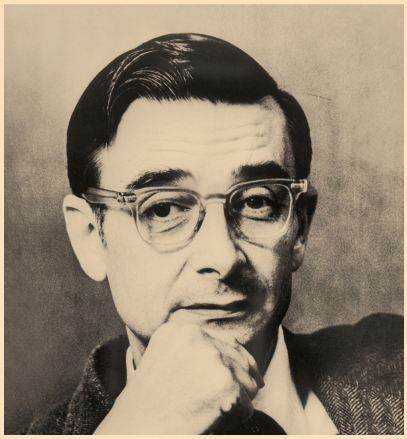
Edward O. Wilson



Born in Alabama in 1929, Edward Osborne Wilson was left blind in one eye after a fishing accident when he was seven, and he switched interests from birdwatching to insects. He discovered the first colony of fire ants in the US when he was only 13, and later attended the University of Alabama and Harvard. Wilson's work has focused primarily on ants but also extends to the study of isolated ecosystems, known as "island biogeography." A leading environmentalist, he has spearheaded efforts to preserve biodiversity and educate people about it. He has been awarded over 150 prizes, including the National Medal for Science, the Cosmos Prize, and two Pulitzer Prizes for nonfiction, and was named one of the century's leading environmentalists by *Time* and *Audubon* magazine.

Key works

1984 *Biophilia*

1998 *Consilience: The Unity of Knowledge*

2014 *The Meaning of Human Existence*

Upsetting the balance

Population growth also drives overharvesting, the final human-made threat to biodiversity in the HIPPO acronym. Found in forestry, livestock grazing, and commercial agriculture, overharvesting can also arise from targeted hunting, gathering, and fishing, as well as unintentional harvesting, such as fish discarded from catches. When the rate of harvest exceeds the rate of